

Chapter 144-1

Before heading back, Xu Qingzhu touched up her lipstick in the car.

She and Liang Shi touched up together.

Both of their makeup had been completely ruined.

Xu Qingzhu's was especially severe. Although she had used waterproof eyeliner and mascara, her tears had still smudged them into dark circles.

It was quite bad, so she simply used makeup remover wipes to take it all off, then casually applied some tone-up cream and lipstick.

It barely passed muster.

Liang Shi didn't say anything. She really couldn't quite figure out these kinds of issues.

When she had said: "Isn't there only one kind of like?"—Xu Qingzhu had stopped having any expectations of her.

And Xu Qingzhu also belatedly realized that she had been too sensitive.

More precisely, she had been very sensitive this whole period.

Especially these past two days.

She kept overthinking about all sorts of things.

Today she had only tentatively voiced her random thoughts, and the result wasn't satisfactory.

But it was also within expectations.

Liang Shi had held her and said: "Xu Qingzhu, only you."

While she was still lucid, she had said in a very tender tone: "I really do like you."

Just this one sentence was better than everything else.

Yet Xu Qingzhu had almost cried again upon hearing it.

Fortunately, she had tidied herself up while still in the car. When she got out, she happened to run into employees from the design department. A group of them had just finished eating outside and were coming back, greeting her cheerfully with smiles as they walked by.

Xu Qingzhu waved at them.

After that, Liang Shi left. Xu Qingzhu stood in place and straightened her clothes. Her pants had gotten somewhat wrinkled, though it wasn't noticeable unless you looked closely.

Only then did she walk toward the office building.

She was still thinking about what had happened earlier as she returned to her office.

When it came to matters regarding Liang Shi, Xu Qingzhu was somewhat avoidant.

Normally, she wanted to get to the bottom of everything and figure things out clearly, unwilling to let any detail slip by.

But lately, when it came to things about Liang Shi, she always just let things slide.

She didn't want to dig into the details.

The habits she had already formed made this extremely painful for her.

She had tried using work to numb herself, but found that these thoughts would pop up unexpectedly. She would even see a couple on the street and think: "Do they really love each other? How do they know for sure?"

Just some wild and random thoughts.

Today's answer had only put her at ease for a moment.

In just the time it took to ride the elevator, Xu Qingzhu was already doubting again—was what Liang Shi said just now true?

Maybe she was lying to her for the sake of those so-called tasks she had to complete.

Maybe she just wanted to brush off her unreasonable emotions.

There were too many possibilities.

So when she entered her office, her mood wasn't good and her thoughts were wandering. As a result, the moment she walked through the door, she walked right into a wall of a person.

Xu Qingzhu stepped back half a step, but then the back of her head bumped against the door.

"Bang."

A very loud sound. It hurt so much that Xu Qingzhu started seeing stars, and she drew in a sharp breath.

Lin Luoxi was also startled and immediately stepped forward to rub her head, saying while rubbing: "Oh dear, what were you thinking about? Be careful!"

"Sorry." Xu Qingzhu said coldly. The continuous pain from the back of her head made her frown.

Lin Luoxi was surprised: "What are you apologizing for? Did you bump yourself silly?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Chapter 144-2

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu finally recovered somewhat. She moved Lin Luoxi's hand away, rubbed her head a few times with one hand, and said while enduring the pain: "I'm fine now."

After saying that, she walked toward her office chair. "What brings you here?"

"What could possibly bring me here?" Lin Luoxi turned back toward the desk. "I just came to see if you'd eaten."

Xu Qingzhu: "...I have."

"I know." Lin Luoxi propped both arms on the desk. "The colleagues from the design department saw you. But I wanted to ask—what's been going on with you lately? You don't even reply to my messages."

Xu Qingzhu took out her phone from her pocket and pressed it, finding that there were indeed many unread messages.

She pressed her lips together, turned off silent mode, and apologized to Lin Luoxi again: "Sorry about that."

"It's fine." Lin Luoxi stared straight at her.

After a moment, Lin Luoxi asked very seriously: "Zhuzi, is something going on with you?"

"Not really." Xu Qingzhu flipped open the documents beside her, twirling a black pen between her fingers twice. Her answer was not very certain.

"If nothing's wrong, then nothing's wrong. Why add 'really'?" Lin Luoxi gave a very certain answer instead: "Zhuzi, something's off with you."

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together, lowering her eyes. "I don't know either."

"Did you fight with Liang Shi?" Lin Luoxi asked.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "No."

"Is it work then?"

"Not that either."

"Did you fight with your parents?"

"No."

Lin Luoxi asked several questions in a row, all of which Xu Qingzhu denied.

Finally, Lin Luoxi couldn't help but ask: "Then what is it?"

"Xixi, why do you like Sally?" Xu Qingzhu asked very seriously.

Lin Luoxi was taken aback. After a moment: "I don't know."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"Strange, right?" Lin Luoxi laughed after saying that. "This person—she's not gentle or considerate, and she doesn't know how to talk. The two of us argue all the time, but I still like her. She doesn't meet a single one of my criteria for a partner, yet I'm set on her."

Xu Qingzhu pondered deeply upon hearing this. "Do you two say 'I love you' to each other?"

"She says it all the time." Lin Luoxi thought about it. "I've never said it."

Lin Luoxi would only cut off all of Sally's sentimental strings whenever Sally got too mushy.

So when Sally said: "Baby, I love you, I love you so much I can't help myself"—Lin Luoxi's response was usually just one word: Scram.

"Maybe it's related to our culture?" Lin Luoxi said: "In the environment we grew up in, we just don't seem to be very good at expressing love."

At this point, Lin Luoxi suddenly changed the topic: "Have you ever seen Sally video call her parents?"

Xu Qingzhu paused, then shook her head: "No."

"When they're on the phone, Sally can say sweet, cutesy things without even thinking about it." Lin Luoxi pulled up a chair and sat across from Xu Qingzhu, casually picking up a pen from the desk and twirling it between her fingers. "One day after listening to her, I tried to imitate it... and my mom said I must be sick."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"I don't know if your family is like that." Lin Luoxi shook her head. "Judging by how President Xu is, he's probably similar to my dad—too blunt. So when I hear Sally say those things, I get goosebumps all over."

"What about when you first started dating?" Xu Qingzhu asked Lin Luoxi about every little detail like a student who had just started school.

"It was okay back then." Lin Luoxi said: "Did you know I had a girlfriend before her?"

"Mm, I even met her." Xu Qingzhu dug up this person from her memory.

That girl was from the medical school. When she was dating Lin Luoxi, she was incredibly busy. Even the time she had to eat with Lin Luoxi was squeezed out. Every time, Lin Luoxi would order the food and wait there for her, waiting until the food went cold before she showed up.

Xu Qingzhu had happened upon this scene many times.

Moreover, that girl was particularly blunt—so blunt that even Lin Luoxi, who wasn't very sentimental in relationships, couldn't accept it.

They naturally broke up later.

Chapter 144-3

Xu Qingzhu still remembered that rainy day. She was walking back to the dorm from the library with an umbrella when she happened to see Lin Luoxi and her girlfriend at the sports field. She was still hesitating whether to greet them when she heard that girl say guiltily to Lin Luoxi: "I shouldn't have wasted your time."

Lin Luoxi responded coldly: "Oh."

There wasn't much dialogue. Lin Luoxi called out to Xu Qingzhu: "Little Zhuzi, give me a ride back."

At that time, she and Lin Luoxi lived in the same dormitory building.

Though not on the same floor.

When they came back, they happened to see Sally standing in the rain downstairs with an umbrella, holding a bouquet of roses.

A blonde, blue-eyed girl, expressing her feelings passionately and sincerely.

This was what Sally said to Lin Luoxi at the time: "I know you have a girlfriend, and I'm not trying to break you up. But today is your birthday, so let me, an admirer, give you a bouquet of flowers. Happy birthday."

Her Chinese wasn't fluent, and when she said this, it was a mix of Chinese and English.

Her tone was particularly amusing.

But no one laughed.

Sally said: "A girl as pretty as you—how can you not have flowers on your birthday?"

Lin Luoxi accepted them, of course, and went into the dormitory building with Xu Qingzhu without much expression.

But while waiting for the elevator, Lin Luoxi quickly walked back out.

Sally happened to still be standing at the entrance, seemingly lost in thought.

Lin Luoxi called out to her: "Hey."

Sally was startled: "Are you calling me?"

Lin Luoxi nodded: "Yeah, you."

Sally: "...What is it?"

"Want to go hiking tomorrow?" Lin Luoxi said: "I just broke up."

Sally was someone who was particularly good at seizing opportunities, so she accepted the olive branch Lin Luoxi extended without hesitation.

Then they dated all the way until graduation.

It wasn't until graduation that Sally hid the fact that she was returning to her home country. She and Lin Luoxi had a huge argument, and only then did the two of them separate.

Xu Qingzhu remembered that she had asked Lin Luoxi at the time: "Do you really like her? Aren't you worried she's a player?"¹

Lin Luoxi told her with great nonchalance: "Youth only lasts a few years. You have to date a few people for it not to be a waste."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Even the hiking trip the next day, Xu Qingzhu had accompanied Lin Luoxi. Bai Weiwei also went along.

Back then, Bai Weiwei rather looked down on Sally, always thinking that Sally was after Lin Luoxi's family connections.

But Xu Qingzhu felt that Sally wasn't scheming at all, and they had been on good terms all the way until now.

As it turned out, she hadn't misjudged people.

The only one she had misjudged was Bai Weiwei.

Back then, Lin Luoxi had also tried to set her up with another girl from the hiking club. She was very good-looking, with a heroic kind of appearance. She always liked wearing white shirts with black pants, paired with white sneakers. She was from the computer science department, and apparently her family was well-off too.

She just wasn't very good at talking. When eating with Xu Qingzhu, the conversation would easily run dry. But she was very obedient and hardworking. Once, Xu Qingzhu's roommate's computer broke down in the middle of the night and she urgently needed to process some files. Xu Qingzhu had no choice but to ask for her help.

The result was that she ran a kilometer from the east side of campus to their dormitory building to fix her roommate's computer.

It's just that there was no spark between Xu Qingzhu and her.

According to Lin Luoxi, that girl actually quite liked her—it was just that Xu Qingzhu showed no reaction at all.

Someone who doesn't receive a response will naturally cool down.

That girl got married last year and even posted about it on social media.

Xu Qingzhu sent her a gift.²

This was the closest she had come to romance in her unremarkable student days.

Later, when she met Liang Shi and said she was getting married, everyone was shocked.

Lin Luoxi was quite surprised: "Other than being a bit richer than Xiao Wu, what else about this person can compare to Xiao Wu?"

Xiao Wu was the girl Lin Luoxi had introduced to her back then.

Xu Qingzhu smiled: "You have to spend time with someone before you can judge, right? I like her."

At the time, she had only said that based on their childhood friendship, and also so that everyone wouldn't worry.

But later, during their daily interactions, Xu Qingzhu silently agreed with Lin Luoxi's words countless times.

That person really couldn't compare to Xiao Wu in any way.

But at that time, Xu Qingzhu's heart was already dead.

How should she describe her state of mind back then?

It was like a flower that bloomed joyfully before its season, only to find it couldn't adapt to the cold weather, withering and dying prematurely.

Meeting Liang Shi again was probably like living toward death.³

So she had been far too careful.

Before, she thought she had everything under control. After going through all those things, her heart could no longer be the same as when she had just reunited with Liang Shi.

Yet she never expected... that was only the beginning.

Afterward, she fell deeper step by step, sinking further step by step.

But she felt that Liang Shi was like a castle in the air—beautiful as a dream, as an illusion.

She couldn't hold onto her.

Footnotes:

¹ **Player** (海王): Literally "Sea King," this is Chinese internet slang for someone who dates or flirts with multiple people at once, similar to a "player" or someone who "has many fish in the sea." The term implies someone who keeps many romantic interests on the hook simultaneously.

² **Sent her a gift** (随了個份子): In Chinese culture, "随份子" refers to giving a monetary gift (usually in a red envelope) for occasions like weddings, births, or funerals. It's a social custom where the amount given often depends on your relationship with the person and is sometimes seen as an obligation within social circles.

³ **Living toward death** (向死而生): A philosophical concept originating from Martin Heidegger's existentialist philosophy, meaning to live authentically by confronting and accepting one's mortality. In this context, it suggests that Xu Qingzhu, whose heart had "died," found new life/purpose through meeting Liang Shi again—being reborn from a state of emotional death.

Chapter 144-4

She had only been reminiscing about Lin Luoxi's romantic issues during university, yet she accidentally thought of Liang Shi again.

Xu Qingzhu's heart felt like a green lime—sour and bitter.

Her expression naturally wasn't good.

Lin Luoxi had been watching her the whole time and could naturally notice her subtle changes. While she was lost in thought, Lin Luoxi waved a hand in front of her face. "What are you thinking about?"

Only then did Xu Qingzhu pull her wandering thoughts back. "Nothing..."

"Because I went through having a partner who wasn't good at talking." Lin Luoxi said: "Someone like Sally is rare and precious. Other than not telling me about that thing at graduation, everything else... has been pretty good."

"Pretty good?" Xu Qingzhu was puzzled.

"Yeah." Lin Luoxi said: "What else? Did you think it was exceptionally good?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"I'm not looking for a perfect lover." Lin Luoxi shrugged: "She can actually only score 70 points, but because I like her, she's full marks. Objectively, all her flaws exist, but subjectively, I can be blind to them."

Without realizing it, Xu Qingzhu had been fed another mouthful of dog food.¹

But...

"Then how did you confirm that she likes you?" Xu Qingzhu asked: "Not just from what she says, but... you clearly feel she treats you well, yet you still feel like she'll leave, that she doesn't actually like you that much, that everything she does is just out of obligation... Like when you and Sally got back together, how did you confirm whether she truly liked you, or whether she just wanted to sleep with you or was using you to pass the time..."

Xu Qingzhu paused, pressed her lips together, and said with some annoyance: "Sorry, I didn't mean to offend."

"I know." Lin Luoxi looked at her. "Zhuzi, you've been so sensitive lately."

Xu Qingzhu was startled: "Huh? Have I?"

"Yes." Lin Luoxi nodded. "Is it because of Liang Shi's coma? You keep feeling like she doesn't love you?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded, then shook her head.

After a moment, she sighed helplessly, lowering her eyes: "I don't know either."

Sometimes she felt Liang Shi loved her very much, and sometimes she felt Liang Shi was just doing it for a task.

This was probably the sorrow of being a detail-oriented person.

She could find evidence that Liang Shi loved her from the details, and she could also find evidence that Liang Shi didn't love her from the details.

So she didn't know.

"Let me answer your earlier question first." Lin Luoxi organized her thoughts. "First of all, I know Sally very well. We've already passed the stage of needing to confirm whether we love each other. At most, what I need to confirm is how much she loves me. Can it surpass her career or other people? But I think these things are meaningless."

Lin Luoxi said: "It's impossible for anyone's life to only have love in it. Just like if I were in Sally's position back then, I would have chosen to go back without hesitation too, because I had responsibilities I had to fulfill. It's just a matter of whether to discuss it with your partner. One of Sally's bad traits is that she likes to avoid things. Back then, she wanted to tell me many times, but she was afraid I'd get angry, so she kept putting it off..."

Put it off until they broke up.

The pen between Xu Qingzhu's fingers kept spinning.

After a long while, Lin Luoxi helped her reach a conclusion: "It's because of Liang Shi's coma, isn't it? Plus these past few days with your heat period, you two have been glued together all day. You've had too much free time."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"I have work too." Xu Qingzhu retorted: "I just can't help but think about it."

Lin Luoxi stared at her, looking at her expression that was startled yet somewhat dazed. She reached out her long arm to ruffle her hair, unable to help but laugh: "Young lady, you're in love."

Xu Qingzhu: "...Haven't I always been in love?"

"No." Lin Luoxi said: "You've entered the honeymoon phase."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She humbly sought advice from Lin Luoxi again, and Lin Luoxi said this was probably a path every couple had to go through.

There would be a long adjustment period.

To adjust to each other's speaking habits, living habits, personalities, including all the little mannerisms.

Half of all couples' love dies during the adjustment period.

Because during the adjustment period, you'll discover this person isn't as wonderful as you imagined, and you'll constantly doubt them because of their actions.

"Then how do you resolve it?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Lin Luoxi: "Communicate tirelessly, suppress the urge to kill her eight hundred times, and tell her how she should talk to you, how she should take care of your fragile heart, how she should give you a sense of security."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"But before that, you have to figure out what you want. What is your sense of security based on?" Lin Luoxi said: "Relationships are like studying. Some people can infer three things from one example, while others might need three examples just to learn one thing."

After saying that, Lin Luoxi stared at Xu Qingzhu and smiled helplessly: "Zhuzi, you're probably just overthinking because your heat period just ended? Wait a while and see. Don't think too much."

Xu Qingzhu nodded and didn't ask any more questions.

But Lin Luoxi added: "I've noticed that you science people easily fall into misconceptions when thinking about relationship problems."

"Hm?" Xu Qingzhu was confused.

"Emotions—especially during the dating period—people's thinking is constantly jumping around, very emotional, like you right now. But people with more rational thinking, when they think about these things, always like to use a fixed measure to compare against. It's as if there's a measuring cup placed there, and the other person's feelings for you have to exceed that amount to count as love."

"But a lot of the time, feelings are unpredictable. She might not love you today, but maybe tomorrow she will. She loves you today, but maybe tomorrow she won't. She might not even understand it herself. When it comes to changing hearts, it doesn't matter how good your partner is—so everything is based on emotion."

"You're too fragile right now." Lin Luoxi looked at her adorably dazed appearance and couldn't help but pat her head again, like petting a cat.² "My little Zhuzi, you love her way too much right now."

Xu Qingzhu stubbornly refused to admit it: "...It's okay, I guess."

"Oh." Lin Luoxi looked into her eyes. "You only cried your makeup off for her, that's all."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

¹ **Dog food** (狗糧): Chinese internet slang for public displays of affection between couples. When someone witnesses a couple being lovey-dovey, they say they've been "fed dog food," implying they're single and watching others be romantic like a lonely dog being fed scraps.

² **Like petting a cat** (跟Rua貓一樣): "Rua" is an onomatopoeia/slang term popular in Chinese internet culture, used to describe the action of affectionately petting, rubbing, or squishing something soft and cute, typically a cat or other fluffy animal. It conveys a sense of fondness and playfulness.

Chapter 144-5

After Lin Luoxi left, Xu Qingzhu kept pondering her words.

—You have to figure out what you want.

Xu Qingzhu thought: what she wanted was Liang Shi's wholehearted love.

Just let her be this greedy.

But she always felt that her current emotions were out of control, and it wasn't entirely related to her heat period.

She had gone through heat periods before, but she had never had these kinds of feelings.

These emotions kept spreading, giving her the feeling that something in her mind was constantly pulling at her.

So much so that she would occasionally have very dangerous thoughts—maybe she should just separate from Liang Shi.

Perhaps she would meet someone better in the future.

But after her rationality returned, she would always find those thoughts completely unreasonable.

As if they weren't thoughts she had come up with herself.

The battle between emotion and reason in her mind left her exhausted in both body and mind.

Lin Luoxi was right—she was indeed fragile and sensitive right now.

Yet her emotions were often pulled to extremes, as if there was a voice in the depths telling her: you should separate from Liang Shi; she isn't the most suitable person for you.

Xu Qingzhu always had to use strong willpower to resist, but occasionally she would still be swept up by these emotions.

It was just that the moment she thought about separating, she felt so sad she could barely breathe.

One night, because she was swept up by her emotions but was also afraid of waking the sleeping Liang Shi, she buried herself under the blanket and cried until she almost couldn't breathe.

This was a terrifying thing.

But Liang Shi didn't know at the time.

While she was still lost in her random thoughts, there was a knock on her office door.

The secretary came in and handed her a stack of documents, then reported her schedule for tomorrow. After pausing for a moment, she said: "President Xu, the Qin family is holding a charity gala next Saturday. Will you be attending?"

Xu Qingzhu paused slightly. "The Qin family that does exports?"

"Yes."

Xu Qingzhu thought for a moment: "I'll go."

"Will you be bringing a family member?" the secretary asked.

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu slowly shook her head: "No."

After saying that, she lowered her eyes, her voice very cold. "Does that side have a requirement to bring a companion?"

The secretary nodded: "It wasn't explicitly stated, but they gave two invitation cards."

"I understand." Xu Qingzhu said: "Leave the invitation on the desk. I'll attend when the time comes."

The secretary handed it over, and Xu Qingzhu opened it to look.

On the gilded invitation, the signature read: Qin Lishuang.